LARSON CAPITAL RESEARCH · AUGUST 2026

The Rent-Growth Screen

Private companies pay heavily for market data. Can you still find an edge with free, public data?

The 110 largest US rental markets, ranked by the fundamentals that historically precede rent growth.

A validated 2025→2028 outlook and a speculative 2026→2029 view, built entirely on free public data.

Frozen · August 2026
every ranking published before its outcome

Graded · early 2029
scored against realized rent growth, whatever it shows

0.43
POOLED TAU ON FINALIZED DATA
RANDOM GUESSING SCORES ABOUT 0

+6.0 pp
TOP-10 EDGE PER COMPLETED WINDOW
NEAR ZERO IN THE 2020–22 SHOCK

110
MARKETS RANKED, EVERY RANKING
FROZEN BEFORE ITS OUTCOME

Ben Larson
Economics and applied mathematics, Indiana University
blarson5187@gmail.com · linkedin.com/in/blarson1105

Model v2.0.0 · methods documented, failures published
A research screen, not investment advice

CONTENTS

In this report

Grading dates are pre-committed: each frozen screen is scored against realized rent growth when its window closes, whatever the result shows.

KEY FINDINGS

What the screen says

The top ten’s rank ranges, drawn to scale: the interval, not the point, is the claim.

- Albany-Schenectady-Troy leads the current screen (a 2025→2028 outlook), lifted most by little new building and strong migration & jobs; its 90% rank range is 1–27.
- The screen’s top-10 markets out-grew the median market by +6.0 points of rent growth over three years, averaged across six completed backtest windows. Picking on recent rent growth alone earned +4.8.
- Every measure had to earn its place by test. An industry-style scorecard rebuilt from the same free data barely beats chance (0.14 on a −1 to +1 rank-agreement scale, vs 0.43 here), and three of this project’s own failed configurations were published as negative results.

Overview

Some rental markets grow rents for years; others stall. This report asks a simple question: can public data tell them apart in advance? The screen ranks the 110 largest US metro areas on fundamentals that historically come before strong rent growth: who is moving in, whether jobs and incomes are growing, how much new housing is being built, and whether rents still have room to rise. Everything is built from free public data (Census, IRS, BLS, BEA, Zillow, FRED), every method is documented, and every published ranking is frozen so its calls can be checked against what actually happens.

Free public data
Census, BLS, BEA, Zillow

→

Eight measures
grouped in five themes

→

Same-year comparison
0 = the average market

→

Fixed public weights
summed into one score

→

Rank and tier
with a 90% rank range

How the score is built, in five steps; the full method is in the back of this report.

The top 10

9 of these ten sit in a 23-market leading cluster; any market in that cluster could plausibly hold a top-10 seat, so treat the exact ordering loosely.

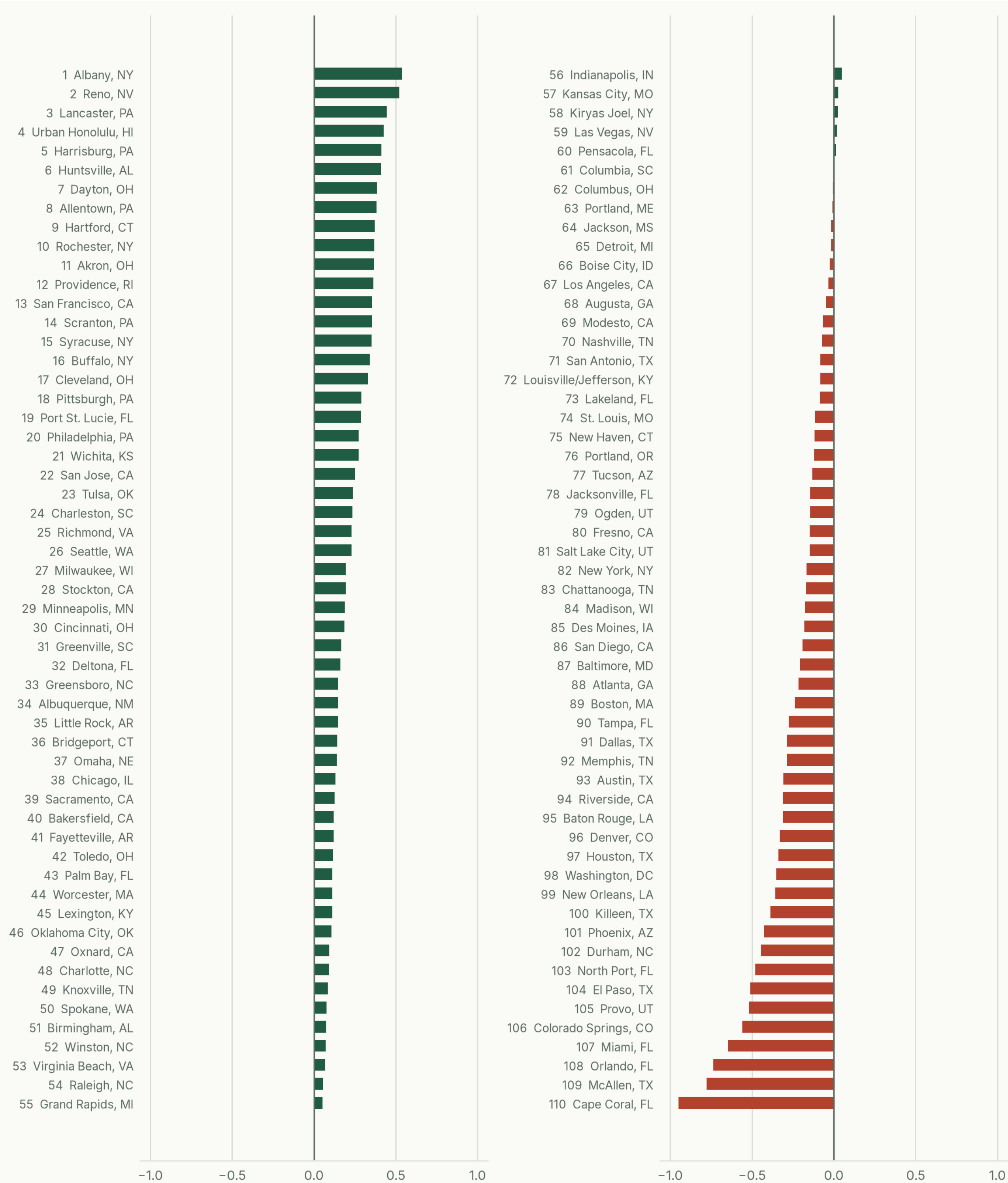
Rank	Metro	Score	What lifts it most
1 (1-27)	Albany-Schenectady-Troy, NY	+0.54	Little new building · Strong migration & jobs
2 (1-28)	Reno, NV	+0.52	Strong migration & jobs · Room for rents to grow
3 (2-37)	Lancaster, PA	+0.45	Little new building · Room for rents to grow
4 (12-76)	Urban Honolulu, HI	+0.43	Little new building · Strong migration & jobs
5 (1-32)	Harrisburg-Carlisle, PA	+0.41	Little new building · Rents climbing
6 (4-48)	Huntsville, AL	+0.41	Strong migration & jobs · Room for rents to grow
7 (2-38)	Dayton-Kettering-Beavercreek, OH	+0.39	Little new building · Strong migration & jobs
8 (5-59)	Allentown-Bethlehem-Easton, PA-NJ	+0.38	Little new building · Strong migration & jobs
9 (2-42)	Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford, CT	+0.37	Little new building · Rents climbing
10 (2-45)	Rochester, NY	+0.37	Little new building · Rents climbing

Rank (90% range), score vs the average market (0), and the themes that lift each score most. The spread between markets matters more than any single value. A market can hold a high single-edition rank while its range sits lower; the tier, not the rank, is the durable claim.

CHART 1

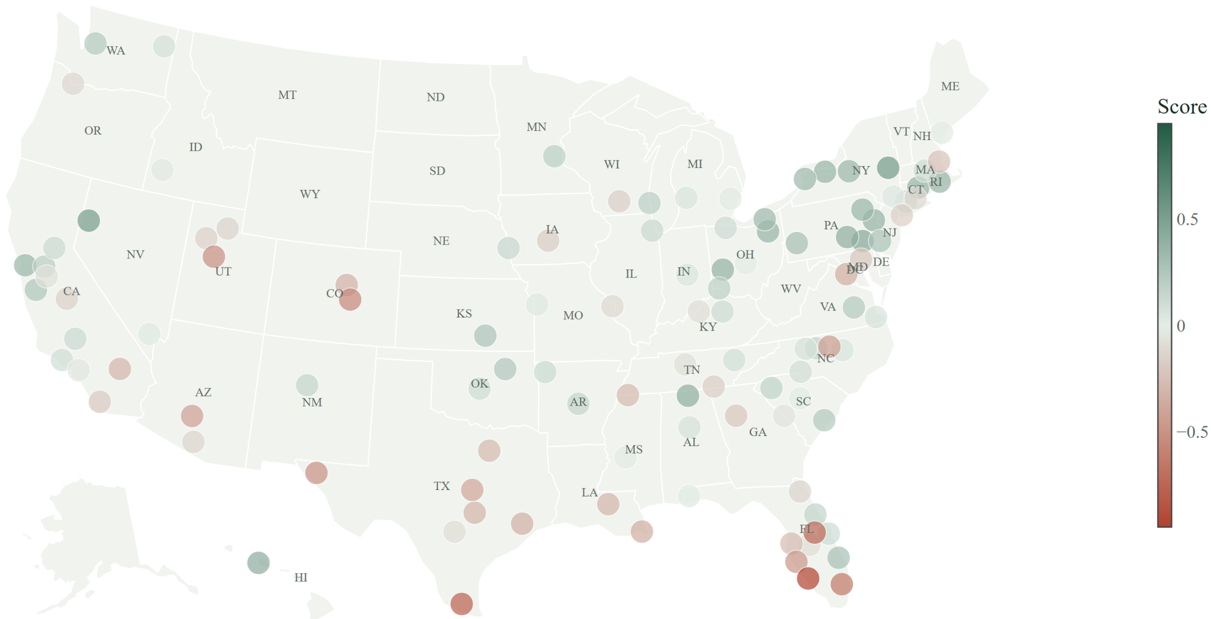
Every market against the average

Composite score for all 110 markets in the 2025 scoring year, relative to the average market (0). Green helps, red hurts.


1 Albany, NY
2 Reno, NV
3 Lancaster, PA
4 Urban Honolulu, HI
5 Harrisburg, PA
6 Huntsville, AL
7 Dayton, OH
8 Allentown, PA
9 Hartford, CT
10 Rochester, NY
11 Akron, OH
12 Providence, RI
13 San Francisco, CA
14 Scranton, PA
15 Syracuse, NY
16 Buffalo, NY
17 Cleveland, OH
18 Pittsburgh, PA
19 Port St. Lucie, FL
20 Philadelphia, PA
21 Wichita, KS
22 San Jose, CA
23 Tulsa, OK
24 Charleston, SC
25 Richmond, VA
26 Seattle, WA
27 Milwaukee, WI
28 Stockton, CA
29 Minneapolis, MN
30 Cincinnati, OH
31 Greenville, SC
32 Deltona, FL
33 Greensboro, NC
34 Albuquerque, NM
35 Little Rock, AR
36 Bridgeport, CT
37 Omaha, NE
38 Chicago, IL
39 Sacramento, CA
40 Bakersfield, CA
41 Fayetteville, AR
42 Toledo, OH
43 Palm Bay, FL
44 Worcester, MA
45 Lexington, KY
46 Oklahoma City, OK
47 Oxnard, CA
48 Charlotte, NC
49 Knoxville, TN
50 Spokane, WA
51 Birmingham, AL
52 Winston, NC
53 Virginia Beach, VA
54 Raleigh, NC
55 Grand Rapids, MI
−1.0
−0.5
0.0
0.5
1.0
56 Indianapolis, IN
57 Kansas City, MO
58 Kiryas Joel, NY
59 Las Vegas, NV
60 Pensacola, FL
61 Columbia, SC
62 Columbus, OH
63 Portland, ME
64 Jackson, MS
65 Detroit, MI
66 Boise City, ID
67 Los Angeles, CA
68 Augusta, GA
69 Modesto, CA
70 Nashville, TN
71 San Antonio, TX
72 Louisville/Jefferson, KY
73 Lakeland, FL
74 St. Louis, MO
75 New Haven, CT
76 Portland, OR
77 Tucson, AZ
78 Jacksonville, FL
79 Ogden, UT
80 Fresno, CA
81 Salt Lake City, UT
82 New York, NY
83 Chattanooga, TN
84 Madison, WI
85 Des Moines, IA
86 San Diego, CA
87 Baltimore, MD
88 Atlanta, GA
89 Boston, MA
90 Tampa, FL
91 Dallas, TX
92 Memphis, TN
93 Austin, TX
94 Riverside, CA
95 Baton Rouge, LA
96 Denver, CO
97 Houston, TX
98 Washington, DC
99 New Orleans, LA
100 Killeen, TX
101 Phoenix, AZ
102 Durham, NC
103 North Port, FL
104 El Paso, TX
105 Provo, UT
106 Colorado Springs, CO
107 Miami, FL
108 Orlando, FL
109 McAllen, TX
110 Cape Coral, FL
−1.0
−0.5
0.0
0.5
1.0

THE MAP

Where the strongest markets are



Green = above the average market (score 0), clay = below; the tiers below group markets the data cannot separate. Albany leads; Reno and Lancaster round out the top three.

The tiers

Single ranks overstate precision, so each market gets a 90% rank range and a tier. Markets in the same tier are peers, not an ordering.

Tier	Markets	Reading
Leading cluster	23	plausibly a top-10 market once measurement noise is accounted for
Strong	16	reliably in the upper ranks, but not a clear top-10 candidate
Mid	32	middle of the pack
Weak	26	reliably in the lower ranks
Lagging	13	at the bottom on these fundamentals

WHAT DRIVES THE RANKINGS

Five themes, eight measures

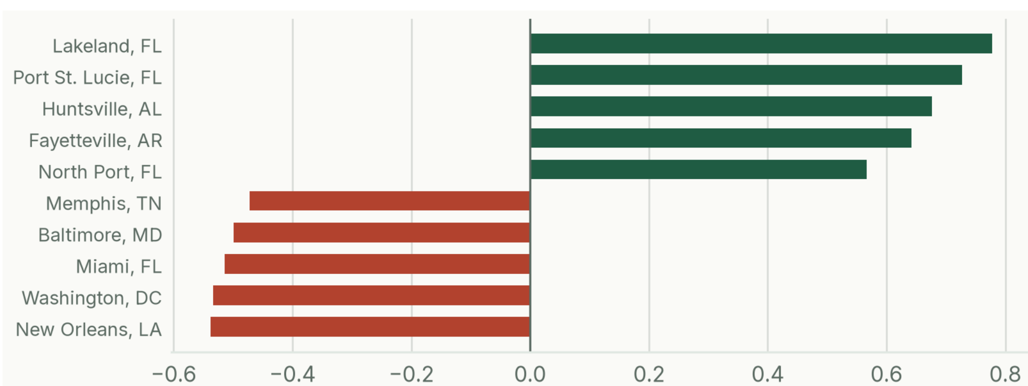
The five published weights, drawn to scale: 40 · 25 · 20 · 10 · 5.

Every market is scored on the same eight measures, grouped into the five themes below (heaviest first). Each measure compares markets within the same year, each theme carries a fixed published weight, and no market is ever hand-adjusted.

Demand: who is moving in, hiring, and earning

Share of the score: 40% of the score.

Net domestic migration, job growth, and income growth. Markets that people and paychecks are moving into fill apartments first and support rent increases later. Migration is the heaviest single measure: the screen’s biggest bet, and the one the backtests reward most.

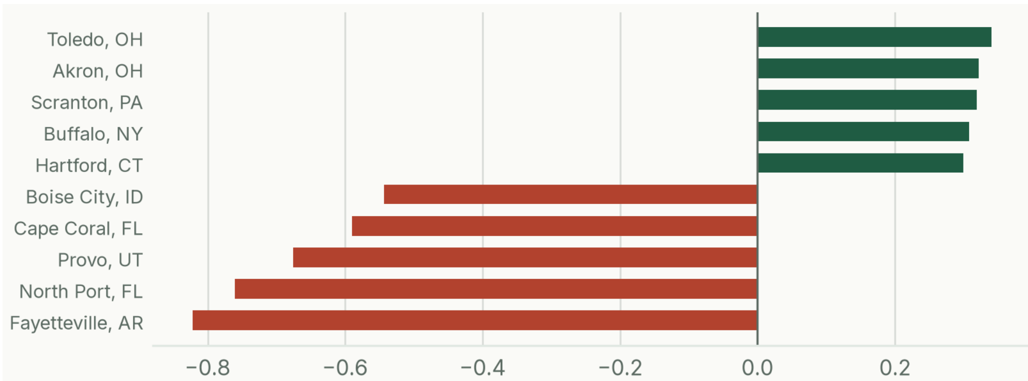


The five markets this theme helps and hurts most. Lakeland-Winter Haven gains the most (+0.78); New Orleans-Metairie gives up the most (−0.54).

Supply: how much new housing is being built

Share of the score: 25% of the score.

Building permits relative to the housing that already exists, counted the opposite way: the less a market is building, the better it scores. Today's construction is tomorrow's competition, the contrarian edge that pushes several fast-growing but over-built Sun Belt markets near the bottom.

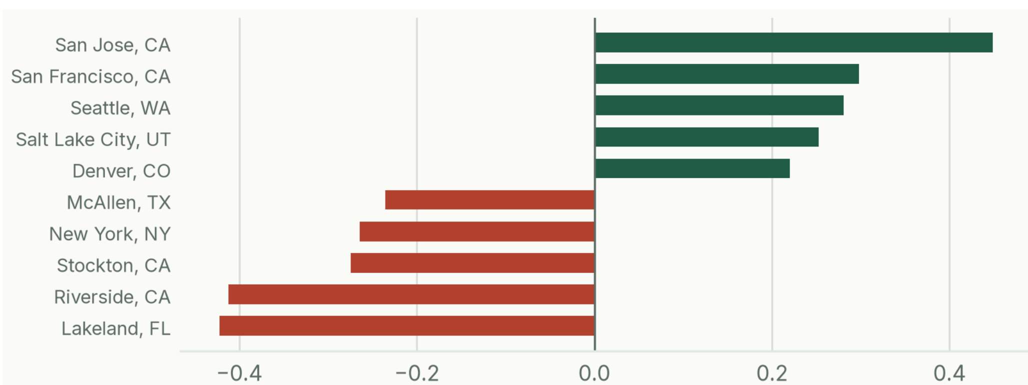


The five markets this theme helps and hurts most. Toledo gains the most (+0.34); Fayetteville-Springdale-Rogers gives up the most (−0.82).

Affordability: whether rents have room to grow

Share of the score: 20% of the score.

Two measures: rent as a share of local income (lower is better; stretched rents have nowhere to go), and the cost of owning versus renting (higher is better; when buying is far pricier than renting, households stay renters longer).

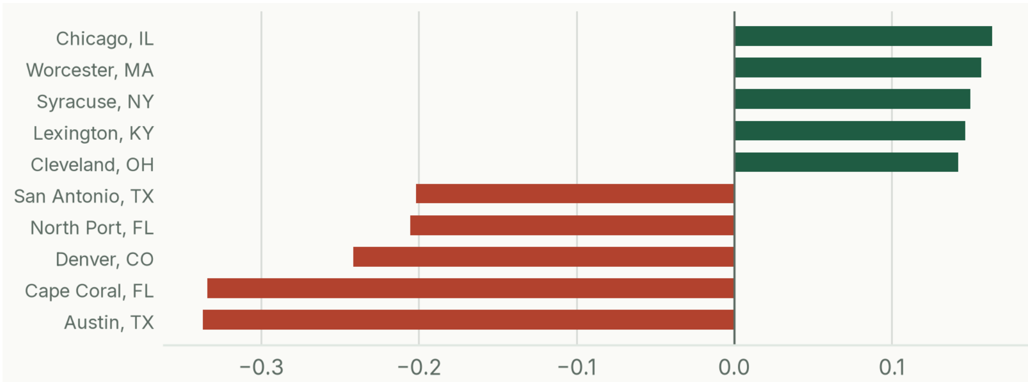


The five markets this theme helps and hurts most. San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara gains the most (+0.45); Lakeland-Winter Haven gives up the most (−0.42).

Momentum: what rents have done lately

Share of the score: a deliberately small 10%.

Recent rent growth, deliberately held to a small weight: informative, but it decays with time and inverted badly in the 2020–22 shock. A supporting witness, not the verdict.

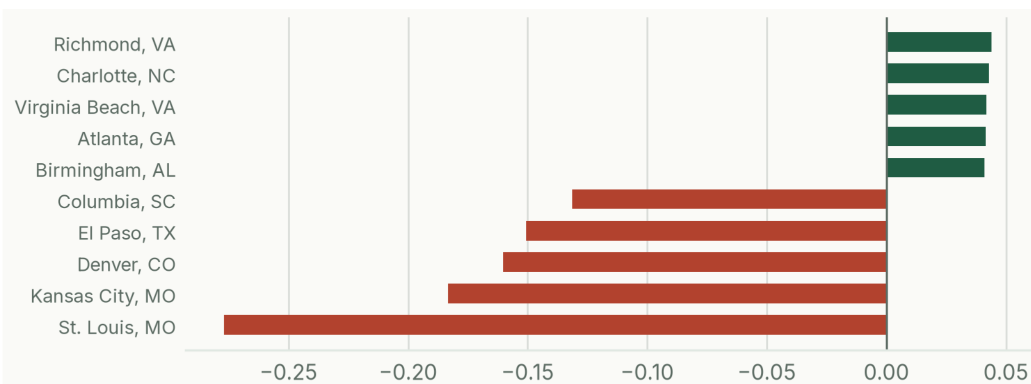


The five markets this theme helps and hurts most. Chicago-Naperville-Elgin gains the most (+0.16); Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos gives up the most (−0.34).

Resilience: how diversified the local economy is

Share of the score: 5% of the score.

Employment spread across industries: a market leaning on one sector carries more downside risk to rents, so diversity earns a small, steady credit.



The five markets this theme helps and hurts most. Richmond gains the most (+0.04); St. Louis gives up the most (−0.28).

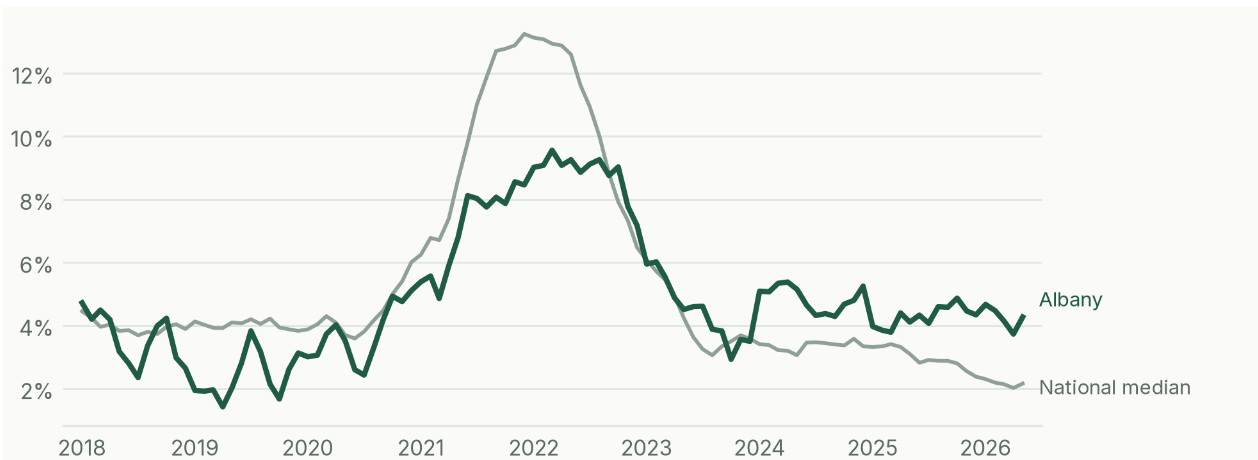
MARKET SPOTLIGHT

The case for Albany-Schenectady-Troy

Albany-Schenectady-Troy, NY ranks #1 of 110 markets, with a rank range of 1–27 and sits in the leading cluster tier. Vs the frozen 2024 edition it held the same rank, inside its own 90% range, expected churn rather than a signal. Its score is built the same way as every other market's; what sets it apart:

- Limited new supply (+0.24 to the score): new building permits vs housing stock: 0.5% of stock (83rd percentile).
- Demand (+0.12 to the score): net domestic migration: +0.12% of population (54th percentile); job growth: +1.3% a year (83rd percentile); income growth: +4.6% a year (76th percentile).

Rents against the national median



Zillow rent index, year over year; the national line is the median of the screened markets. History describes the past; the rank comes from the fundamentals above.

A #1 rank is a screening result, not a verdict: under alternative weightings this market ranks as low as #27. Read the top of the table as a group of strong candidates.

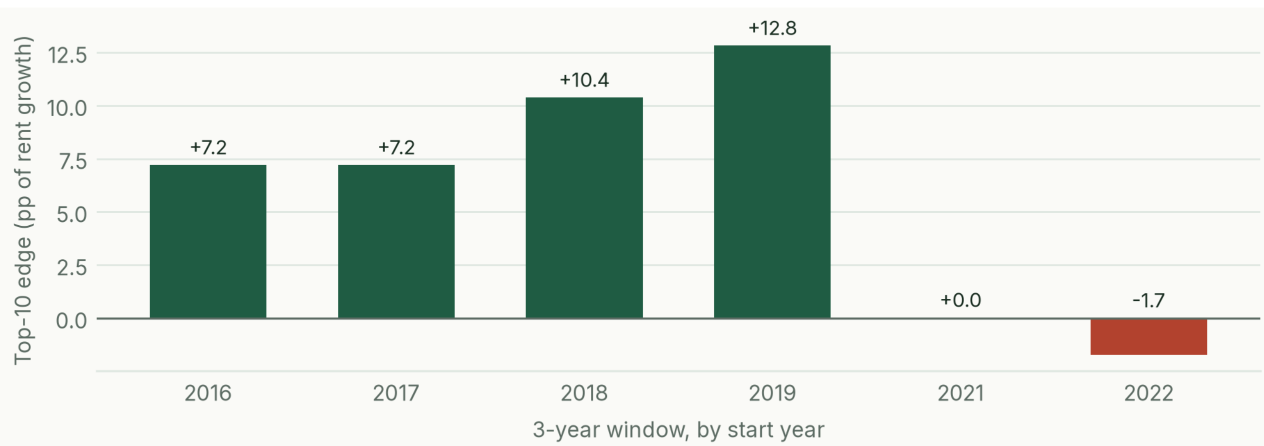
HAS IT WORKED?

The track record

Six completed windows' top-10 edge, with the freeze-then-grade rail beneath: frozen at publication, graded three years on.

How every window is graded, shown for 2019: the call is frozen at publication and scored three years later.

Each completed three-year window is graded the same way: how much more rent growth did the screen's top-10 markets deliver than the median market?



Calm windows came in between +7.2 and +12.8 points. The shock (2020–22) windows were roughly flat; picking on rent momentum alone turned firmly negative in those same windows. The screen earns its edge in normal conditions and loses most of it in shocks.

What was achievable in real time

The same backtest, two ways: real-time uses only data a user could have had at the time; finalized uses the complete revised data that arrives about two years later, a ceiling no live user ever had. Agreement is weighted Kendall's tau, a rank-agreement score from −1 to +1 where 0 means no relationship.

Period	Tau (real-time)	Tau (finalized)	P@10 (real-time)	P@10 (finalized)
Pre-COVID	0.60	0.59	85%	85%
Shock (2020-22)	0.07	0.13	20%	25%
All periods	0.42	0.43	63%	65%

3-year horizon. Real-time numbers come from the pseudo-nowcast test, a disclosed simplification. Data vintage: finalized panel through 2024; rent index through May 2026.

How to read these numbers

Tau (rank agreement)	How well the ranking agreed with the rent growth that followed, from −1 to +1; 0 means no relationship, and random guessing scores about 0.
Precision@10 (P@10)	Of the screen's ten highest-ranked markets, the share that landed in the top quarter by actual rent growth.
Top-10 edge (points)	How many percentage points more rent growth the top ten delivered than the median market over the window.
Rank range and tier	Where a rank lands 90% of the time once measurement noise is accounted for; same-tier markets are peers, not an ordering.

Against an industry ranking

Prominent 2026 industry opportunity rankings are built the way this project's benchmark scorecard is: equal weights across categories, chosen without validation, published as point ranks with no uncertainty attached. Within six months, roughly half of one such ranking's markets moved by double-digit ranks, churn of the kind this screen's rank ranges are built to absorb. Rebuilt from the same free public data, that scorecard style agrees with realized 3-year rent growth at 0.14 on the −1 to +1 tau scale; this screen's finalized-data figure is 0.43. A comparison of methods, not of any vendor's product at its own task.

Five gates, three failures, two passes

Every screen built on early or estimated data had to pass the same pre-registered test (keep at least 85% of the finalized model's signal and match its top 10 on at least 7 of 10 names) in a single attempt, with the outcome published either way:

×	1.	2025 screen, five estimated inputs kept 74.8% of the signal; never shipped.	**Failed**
×	2.	2025 screen, fresher jobs data kept 84.66%; not rounded up; the edition was pulled.	**Failed by 0.34 pt**
✓	3.	2024-vintage screen, one estimated input kept 95.5%, matched the top-10 on 8.3/10 (a 2024-2027 forecast).	**Passed**
✓	4.	2025 screen, income chained by state growth kept 96.6%, matched the top-10 on 7.4/10; this report's current 2025-2028 forecast.	**Passed**
×	5.	Mid-year 2026 screen, five months of data kept 82.7% and matched 4.8 of 10 (averaged across the test windows); it appears in this report only as a clearly-labeled speculative outlook, never as a validated screen.	**Failed both bars**

A validation bar that never fails anything proves nothing. Ours failed three of five attempts, which is exactly why the two that passed mean something.

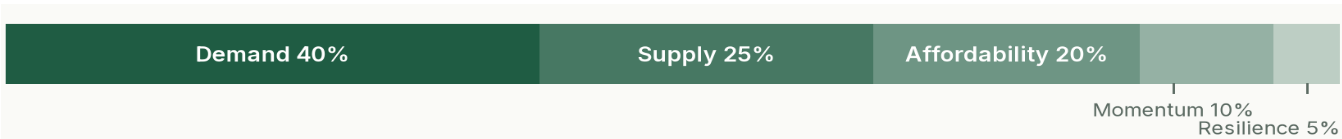
Honest limits

- The rent data measures asking rents, not signed leases.
- No capital-markets or operating-cost data (sale prices, cap rates, insurance, taxes); rent growth stands in for profitability.
- Measure weights are set by judgment and tested, not statistically fitted.
- The supply measure reads permit levels in the scoring year; a sharp turn in construction starts shows up only as it enters the permit data, so supply inflections can lag.
- In shock periods like 2020–22 the screen loses most of its edge; treat it as a screen, not a forecast.

METHODOLOGY

How the score is built

The screen scores every market on 8 measures, grouped into five themes. Each measure compares a market against all the others in the same year, so a nationwide swing cancels out and only relative standing counts. Measures where more is worse (heavy homebuilding, rents that already stretch incomes) are flipped, so higher always means better. Each measure is multiplied by a fixed weight and summed into one composite score; markets are ranked by it. The same formula runs for every market; no market is ever hand-adjusted.



Theme	Weight	Measures (weight)
Demand	40%	Net domestic migration (20%) · Job growth (12%) · Income growth (8%)
Supply	25%	New building permits vs housing stock (25%)
Affordability	20%	Rent as a share of income (12%) · Cost to own vs rent (8%)
Momentum	10%	Recent rent growth (10%)
Resilience	5%	Employment diversity (5%)

The weights are fixed, published in full, set by judgment rather than fitted, and stress-tested: reasonable alternative weightings score about the same, so the testing, not the weights, is the point.

Where the data comes from

Measure	Source	Through
Net domestic migration	Census population estimates, net domestic migration (a validated substitute for the slower IRS data) · source page	2024
Job growth	BLS employment census (QCEW) · source page	2024 *
Income growth	BEA county personal income, rolled up to metros · source page	2024 *
New building permits vs housing stock	Census building permits over ACS housing stock · source page	2024
Rent as a share of income	Zillow rent index vs BEA income · source page	2024
Cost to own vs rent	Zillow home values vs rents, with mortgage rates (FRED); built from county home values for Dayton and Poughkeepsie, which Zillow does not publish at the metro level · source page	2024
Recent rent growth	Zillow rent index (ZORI) · source page	2024
Employment diversity	BLS employment census (QCEW), industry mix · source page	2024

* The three Connecticut metros' job and income growth are chained across a 2023–24 state geography change using validated substitutes, a disclosed fix for those three markets only. The current screen's slowest inputs use validated substitutes (Census migration, monthly employment, state-chained income); the configuration passed its pre-registered gate at 96.6% signal retention.

SPECULATIVE OUTLOOK

The speculative 2026–2029 outlook

The freeze-grade rail breaks here: this configuration failed its validation gate and makes no graded claim.

This screen has not passed validation. Read every rank loosely.
Tested on history the same way as every published screen, this recipe keeps 89.0% of the finalized model's signal but matches the finalized top-10 on only 5.0 of 10 names (a validated screen needs 7), falling to 3–4 of 10 in fast-moving years. An earlier mid-year recipe failed its one-shot gate outright (82.7% and 4.8 of 10). For decisions, use the validated 2025→2028 screen in the body of this report.

This is the same frozen model run on data through May 2026: five months of rents, jobs, home values, and permits; migration one year stale; and income growth estimated from each metro's state, so metros in the same state share one income figure.

The speculative top 10

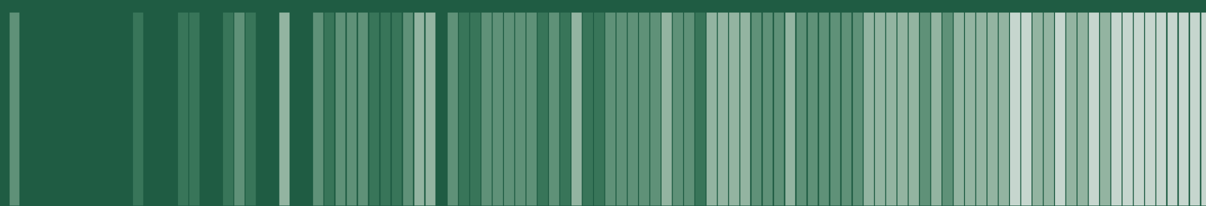
Rank	Metro	Score	What lifts it most
1	Reno, NV	+0.76	Strong migration & jobs
2	Albany-Schenectady-Troy, NY	+0.57	Little new building
3	San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont, CA	+0.49	Little new building
4	Dayton-Kettering-Beavercreek, OH	+0.48	Little new building
5	Lancaster, PA	+0.48	Little new building
6	Wichita, KS	+0.46	Strong migration & jobs
7	Akron, OH	+0.45	Little new building
8	Huntsville, AL	+0.44	Strong migration & jobs
9	Scranton--Wilkes-Barre, PA	+0.43	Little new building
10	Providence-Warwick, RI-MA	+0.42	Little new building

No rank ranges are shown: this configuration failed validation, so the ordering is indicative at best. A working view, rebuilt as data lands; unlike the validated screens it is not frozen to the registry and makes no graded claim. The full speculative ranking and per-market detail are on the companion site.

APPENDIX

All 110 markets

All 110 markets as one strip, colored by tier, leading cluster to lagging: the legend for the table that follows.



Treat this as a screen, not a precise ordering: the range beside each rank shows where that rank lands 90% of the time once measurement noise is accounted for, and markets with overlapping ranges are roughly tied.

Rank moves mix one real year of market change with measurement noise; a move inside a market's own 90% range is expected, not a signal. Historically even two fully finalized years share only 1 to 6 of the same top-10 names. Gray moves are expected churn; colored moves fall outside the market's prior 90% range.

Rank	Metro	Score	Vs 2024	Top strength	Top drag
1 (1-27)	Albany-Schenectady-Troy, NY	+0.54	0	Little new building	No material drag
2 (1-28)	Reno, NV	+0.52	+50	Strong migration & jobs	No material drag
3 (2-37)	Lancaster, PA	+0.45	+8	Little new building	No material drag
4 (12-76)	Urban Honolulu, HI	+0.43	+59	Little new building	Rents already stretched
5 (1-32)	Harrisburg-Carlisle, PA	+0.41	+19	Little new building	Concentrated economy
6 (4-48)	Huntsville, AL	+0.41	-2	Strong migration & jobs	Heavy construction
7 (2-38)	Dayton-Kettering-Beavercreek, OH	+0.39	+3	Little new building	No material drag
8 (5-59)	Allentown-Bethlehem-Easton, PA-NJ	+0.38	+67	Little new building	Rents already stretched
9 (2-42)	Hartford-West Hartford-East Hartford, CT	+0.37	-6	Little new building	Weak demand
10 (2-45)	Rochester, NY	+0.37	-3	Little new building	Weak demand
11 (1-24)	Akron, OH	+0.37	+5	Little new building	Weak demand
12 (3-50)	Providence-Warwick, RI-MA	+0.36	+5	Little new building	Rents already stretched
13 (1-33)	San Francisco-Oakland-Fremont, CA	+0.36	+42	Room for rents to grow	Weak demand
14 (2-40)	Scranton--Wilkes-Barre, PA	+0.36	+5	Little new building	Rents already stretched
15 (7-71)	Syracuse, NY	+0.35	-13	Little new building	Rents already stretched
16 (3-45)	Buffalo-Cheektowaga, NY	+0.34	-7	Little new building	Weak demand
17 (1-36)	Cleveland, OH	+0.33	-5	Little new building	Weak demand
18 (4-51)	Pittsburgh, PA	+0.29	+14	Little new building	Weak demand
19 (7-63)	Port St. Lucie, FL	+0.29	+45	Strong migration & jobs	Heavy construction

Rank	Metro	Score	Vs 2024	Top strength	Top drag
20 (8-66)	Philadelphia-Camden-Wilmington, PA-NJ-DE-M	+0.27	+37	Little new building	Concentrated economy
21 (6-61)	Wichita, KS	+0.27	+21	Room for rents to grow	No material drag
22 (4-53)	San Jose-Sunnyvale-Santa Clara, CA	+0.25	+17	Room for rents to grow	Weak demand
23 (8-67)	Tulsa, OK	+0.24	-17	Strong migration & jobs	Concentrated economy
24 (14-79)	Charleston-North Charleston, SC	+0.23	-10	Strong migration & jobs	Heavy construction
25 (7-66)	Richmond, VA	+0.23	-10	Strong migration & jobs	Heavy construction
26 (3-54)	Seattle-Tacoma-Bellevue, WA	+0.23	+22	Room for rents to grow	Weak demand
27 (2-44)	Milwaukee-Waukesha, WI	+0.20	-2	Little new building	Weak demand
28 (43-97)	Stockton-Lodi, CA	+0.19	+30	Strong migration & jobs	Rents already stretched
29 (6-62)	Minneapolis-St. Paul-Bloomington, MN-WI	+0.19	+25	Room for rents to grow	Weak demand
30 (6-63)	Cincinnati, OH-KY-IN	+0.19	+19	Little new building	Weak demand
31 (17-81)	Greenville-Anderson-Greer, SC	+0.17	+20	Strong migration & jobs	Heavy construction
32 (7-65)	Deltona-Daytona Beach-Ormond Beach, FL	+0.16	-4	Strong migration & jobs	Rents already stretched
33 (14-77)	Greensboro-High Point, NC	+0.15	+23	Strong migration & jobs	No material drag
34 (15-79)	Albuquerque, NM	+0.15	-8	Little new building	Concentrated economy
35 (13-73)	Little Rock-North Little Rock-Conway, AR	+0.15	-30	Little new building	Concentrated economy
36 (9-72)	Bridgeport-Stamford-Danbury, CT	+0.14	-23	Room for rents to grow	Weak demand
37 (13-75)	Omaha, NE-IA	+0.14	+48	Room for rents to grow	Heavy construction
38 (10-74)	Chicago-Naperville-Elgin, IL-IN	+0.13	+43	Little new building	Weak demand
39 (29-90)	Sacramento-Roseville-Folsom, CA	+0.13	-4	Strong migration & jobs	Rents already stretched
40 (45-98)	Bakersfield-Delano, CA	+0.12	+28	Strong migration & jobs	Rents already stretched
41 (43-97)	Fayetteville-Springdale-Rogers, AR	+0.12	-5	Strong migration & jobs	Heavy construction
42 (4-54)	Toledo, OH	+0.12	+11	Little new building	Weak demand
43 (15-77)	Palm Bay-Melbourne-Titusville, FL	+0.11	-13	Strong migration & jobs	Rents already stretched
44 (8-66)	Worcester, MA	+0.11	+25	Little new building	Weak demand
45 (11-72)	Lexington-Fayette, KY	+0.11	-16	Rents climbing	Weak demand
46 (15-79)	Oklahoma City, OK	+0.11	-3	Strong migration & jobs	Heavy construction
47 (26-86)	Oxnard-Thousand Oaks-Ventura, CA	+0.09	-24	Little new building	Rents already stretched
48 (25-87)	Charlotte-Concord-Gastonia, NC-SC	+0.09	+35	Strong migration & jobs	Heavy construction
49 (24-85)	Knoxville, TN	+0.09	-16	Strong migration & jobs	Heavy construction
50 (15-81)	Spokane-Spokane Valley, WA	+0.08	+29	Room for rents to grow	Rents cooling
51 (8-65)	Birmingham, AL	+0.07	-33	Little new building	Weak demand
52 (13-77)	Winston-Salem, NC	+0.07	+19	Strong migration & jobs	Heavy construction
53 (9-71)	Virginia Beach-Chesapeake-Norfolk, VA-NC	+0.07	-19	Little new building	Weak demand
54 (45-98)	Raleigh-Cary, NC	+0.06	+22	Strong migration & jobs	Heavy construction
55 (11-73)	Grand Rapids-Wyoming-Kentwood, MI	+0.05	+5	Little new building	Weak demand
56 (12-73)	Indianapolis-Carmel-Greenwood, IN	+0.05	-25	Rents climbing	Weak demand
57 (18-86)	Kansas City, MO-KS	+0.03	+5	Rents climbing	Concentrated economy
58 (33-93)	Kiryas Joel-Poughkeepsie-Newburgh, NY	+0.03	-14	Little new building	Rents already stretched

Rank	Metro	Score	Vs 2024	Top strength	Top drag
59 (33-92)	Las Vegas-Henderson-North Las Vegas, NV	+0.02	-19	Strong migration & jobs	Heavy construction
60 (28-90)	Pensacola-Ferry Pass-Brent, FL	+0.01	+14	Strong migration & jobs	Rents already stretched
61 (29-91)	Columbia, SC	+0.00	-20	Strong migration & jobs	Concentrated economy
62 (41-96)	Columbus, OH	-0.01	+10	Strong migration & jobs	Heavy construction
63 (26-87)	Portland-South Portland, ME	-0.01	-43	Rents climbing	Concentrated economy
64 (27-88)	Jackson, MS	-0.02	+3	Little new building	Weak demand
65 (11-70)	Detroit-Warren-Dearborn, MI	-0.02	+1	Little new building	Weak demand
66 (46-98)	Boise City, ID	-0.02	-28	Strong migration & jobs	Heavy construction
67 (36-94)	Los Angeles-Long Beach-Anaheim, CA	-0.03	-2	Little new building	Weak demand
68 (37-96)	Augusta-Richmond County, GA-SC	-0.05	+31	Strong migration & jobs	Rents already stretched
69 (55-99)	Modesto, CA	-0.07	-24	Little new building	Rents already stretched
70 (37-95)	Nashville-Davidson--Murfreesboro--Franklin	-0.07	+14	Strong migration & jobs	Heavy construction
71 (29-89)	San Antonio-New Braunfels, TX	-0.08	+17	Little new building	Rents cooling
72 (18-80)	Louisville/Jefferson County, KY-IN	-0.08	-45	Room for rents to grow	Weak demand
73 (53-101)	Lakeland-Winter Haven, FL	-0.09	+35	Strong migration & jobs	Rents already stretched
74 (22-86)	St. Louis, MO-IL	-0.11	+8	Little new building	Weak demand
75 (21-86)	New Haven, CT	-0.12	-53	Little new building	Weak demand
76 (16-79)	Portland-Vancouver-Hillsboro, OR-WA	-0.12	+13	Room for rents to grow	Weak demand
77 (25-87)	Tucson, AZ	-0.13	+15	Little new building	Weak demand
78 (32-93)	Jacksonville, FL	-0.14	-1	Strong migration & jobs	Heavy construction
79 (33-93)	Ogden, UT	-0.15	-9	Room for rents to grow	Weak demand
80 (58-102)	Fresno, CA	-0.15	-43	Little new building	Rents already stretched
81 (54-101)	Salt Lake City-Murray, UT	-0.15	-3	Room for rents to grow	Weak demand
82 (51-99)	New York-Newark-Jersey City, NY-NJ	-0.17	+5	Little new building	Rents already stretched
83 (37-95)	Chattanooga, TN-GA	-0.17	-24	Strong migration & jobs	Concentrated economy
84 (43-98)	Madison, WI	-0.17	-34	Room for rents to grow	Heavy construction
85 (33-95)	Des Moines-West Des Moines, IA	-0.18	-64	Room for rents to grow	Heavy construction
86 (57-101)	San Diego-Chula Vista-Carlsbad, CA	-0.19	+8	Little new building	Weak demand
87 (19-82)	Baltimore-Columbia-Towson, MD	-0.21	-79	Little new building	Weak demand
88 (48-98)	Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell, GA	-0.21	+8	Diverse economy	Weak demand
89 (38-94)	Boston-Cambridge-Newton, MA-NH	-0.24	+2	Little new building	Weak demand
90 (62-102)	Tampa-St. Petersburg-Clearwater, FL	-0.27	+5	Diverse economy	Rents already stretched
91 (67-104)	Dallas-Fort Worth-Arlington, TX	-0.29	+13	Room for rents to grow	Heavy construction
92 (46-98)	Memphis, TN-MS-AR	-0.29	+9	Little new building	Weak demand
93 (82-106)	Austin-Round Rock-San Marcos, TX	-0.31	+14	Strong migration & jobs	Heavy construction
94 (78-105)	Riverside-San Bernardino-Ontario, CA	-0.31	-4	Little new building	Rents already stretched
95 (40-98)	Baton Rouge, LA	-0.31	-49	Room for rents to grow	Weak demand
96 (65-104)	Denver-Aurora-Centennial, CO	-0.33	+2	Room for rents to grow	Rents cooling
97 (75-105)	Houston-Pasadena-The Woodlands, TX	-0.34	+5	Diverse economy	Heavy construction

Rank	Metro	Score	Vs 2024	Top strength	Top drag
98 (36-95)	Washington-Arlington-Alexandria, DC-VA-MD-	-0.35	-51	Little new building	Weak demand
99 (59-102)	New Orleans-Metairie, LA	-0.36	-26	Little new building	Weak demand
100 (74-105)	Killeen-Temple, TX	-0.39	0	Broadly average	Heavy construction
101 (67-104)	Phoenix-Mesa-Chandler, AZ	-0.42	-15	Room for rents to grow	Heavy construction
102 (81-106)	Durham-Chapel Hill, NC	-0.45	-41	Room for rents to grow	Heavy construction
103 (98-109)	North Port-Bradenton-Sarasota, FL	-0.48	-6	Strong migration & jobs	Heavy construction
104 (93-108)	El Paso, TX	-0.51	-11	Little new building	Weak demand
105 (98-109)	Provo-Orem-Lehi, UT	-0.52	-2	Strong migration & jobs	Heavy construction
106 (80-106)	Colorado Springs, CO	-0.56	-26	Room for rents to grow	Weak demand
107 (100-109)	Miami-Fort Lauderdale-West Palm Beach, FL	-0.65	-2	Little new building	Weak demand
108 (103-110)	Orlando-Kissimmee-Sanford, FL	-0.74	-2	Diverse economy	Heavy construction
109 (106-110)	McAllen-Edinburg-Mission, TX	-0.78	+1	Broadly average	Heavy construction
110 (107-110)	Cape Coral-Fort Myers, FL	-0.95	-1	Strong migration & jobs	Heavy construction

ABOUT

About this research

My name is Ben Larson, and I am a junior at Indiana University studying economics and applied math. My research interests center on quantitative market selection: applying data to identify optimal real estate markets across the U.S. and to help inform investment decisions across commercial real estate asset classes, including multifamily, industrial, retail, office, and data centers.

Everything here is held to a standard worth defending: every method documented, every claim validated before it is published, failed experiments published alongside the successes, and a frozen track record anyone can check against what actually happens.

Contact: blarson5187@gmail.com · linkedin.com/in/blarson1105

The interactive version of this report, with every market's detail page, side-by-side comparisons, and the full validation record, is on the companion site.

Disclaimer